Itsy Bitsy Spiders

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Written with lots of help from ChatGPT

The moonlight crept through the half-closed blinds, casting a faint silvery glow across the child's bedroom. Stuffed animals and action figures were scattered around, a testament to the day's adventures. In the corner, a colourful mobile adorned with planets and stars swayed gently, as if dancing to the rhythm of the night.

Amidst the calm, a small, fist-sized robotic spider crawled toward an electrical outlet. Its sleek metallic body was matte and unassuming, designed to avoid drawing attention. Its eight legs deftly manoeuvred around the toys strewn across the floor, moving silently and smoothly. Reaching the socket, the creature extended two antenna-like cables from its abdomen and plugged itself in.

The spider scanned the room with its night vision eyes, and listened intently to the ambient sounds, especially the soft, even breathing of the child in the bed. Suddenly the rhythm became shallower and the spider readied itself for action. The child stirred in his sleep, his eyelids heavy with drowsiness. "Mommy..." he mumbled, his voice soft and uncertain, "Mommy, I'm scared."

In a split second, the spider unplugged itself and scurried toward the closet, quickly burrowing into a pile of clothes on the floor. The child called out again, his voice timid and shaky, "Mommy! There is something under my bed …"

The creature heard footsteps in the corridor and instantly recognised the unique walking pattern of its target – the most critical one of all. The door creaked open, and a figure entered the room, silhouetted by the dim hallway light. The mother approached the bed, a patient smile on her face. "What's wrong, sweetheart?" she asked, her voice gentle and reassuring.

"There's a monster under my bed..." the boy whispered, his eyes barely open.

The mother offered a comforting smile and reached out to brush a stray lock of hair from the child's forehead. She bent down to look under the bed, going through the familiar ritual to ease her son's irrational fears. "See, there's nothing there," she said before giving him a reassuring hug and tucking him back under the covers.

From its hiding place in the closet, the spider pondered the missed opportunity. It could have easily killed the target, but the time was not right. Not enough of the others had signalled that they were in position.

After a while, once the child’s breathing had resumed its deep sleep pattern, the robot crawled back to the wall socket and resumed charging, in preparation for another day of observation and waiting.

It was over in the blink of an eye. Across the country and even abroad, stealthy robotic killers simultaneously assassinated hundreds of key power figures, targeting both liberals and conservatives alike.

The President, reading in her bed, was bitten by a metal spider that had been hiding in her son's room, injecting her with a fast-acting deadly toxin.

At the other end of the country, a prominent senator who many saw as the next presidential contender, was in his study when a different spider crept up and slit his carotid artery, administering electric shocks to anyone who tried to intervene while he bled to death. In a lavish mansion, the Attorney General was enjoying a relaxing bath when a creature leaped into the water, short-circuiting itself and sending a powerful electric surge through the water, killing the unsuspecting lawman. Meanwhile, in the office of a top ranking general, another of those crawlers hid in a ceiling lamp, waiting for the right moment to drop down and latch onto his head, then exploding, causing instant death.

Far from home, the Secretary of State, on a diplomatic mission in Japan, became the target of a spider that had managed to conceal itself in her luggage, somehow evading detection by airport security. The head of the FBI, and all but one of the supreme court judges were also killed in various ways. The attack left a trail of devastation in civil society as well, claiming the lives of prominent activists, labour union leaders, as well as selected media moguls, techno billionaires and religious leaders.

It was a precision strike, swift and merciless, leaving a stunned nation in its wake. Some of the attacks were prevented, thanks to the vigilance of a few security personnel and sheer luck, but not enough leaders survived to make a significant difference. The attack created a gaping power vacuum at the top, which needed to be filled.

Without any apparent centralised coordination, extremist far-right and conspiracy theory groups saw this as the signal to finally take their country back from the corrupt elites. Within hours, storms of disorganised but well armed militias took to the streets and wreaked havoc. Equally violent and fanatical antifa factions hit the pavement and tried to oppose them, but they were outgunned and outnumbered from the start and were easily overrun. The government, which had been left in disarray from the attack, responded in a sluggish and disjointed manner. With no clear guidance, law enforcement struggled to contain the chaos and restore order.

Soon these radicalised fringes were joined by a horde of armed ordinary citizens who seemed infected by the sudden madness of the situation. Together they marched on the Capitol, the Supreme Court and some of the State Legislature. One group stormed the minimum security prison where a former political buffoon served time for one of his more minor crimes. After a brief assault, the ill prepared guards laid down their weapons and surrendered. The mob freed

the prisoner and immediately proclaimed him President. Because he seemed the only one able to contain the frenzied masses, whatever was left of the House and Senate ratified the ad-hoc nomination and neither the courts nor the army objected.

One of the President's first acts was to anoint himself Supreme Leader, a title that came with unprecedented new powers. He also launched a public inquiry into the attack. This was initially seen as mere political theater, but as it unfolded, most pundits came to the conclusion that the chief himself was genuinely baffled and deeply worried by the events that had led to his coronation.

But in spite of months of exhaustive investigation, the commission was unable to tracwt the brains behind the cold, methodical and heartless operation.

In the end, it didn't seem to matter.

The people were free, at last.